The intense loyalty the deras in turn inspire cannot be underestimated. Their fulfilment of people's basic needs is suffused with the religious fervour that comes along with affiliation to a spiritual guru. And most of them are led by figures less ostentatious and controversial than Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh Insan. But social and economic insecurity is at the heart of a dera's religious appeal and its fanatic following. Where government and civil society failed, a seeming charlatan with an insatiable lust succeeded, and his success mattered far more than his flaws. People who were willing to lend their wives and daughters to their guru could not understand why the same 'blessing' extended to two girls should land him in jail. As an anonymous posting on social media pointed out, 'a lost man doesn't care if a rapist gives him direction. A hungry man will take food from a murderer's hand'.

The mass upsurge by dera followers on their guru's conviction revealed their fears that without him and his organisation, they might once again slide back into the margins. This explains the intensity of their identification with him, whatever he does. They are literally willing to kill for him or, as they might see it, for themselves. Many Indians lamented that such blind religious devotion should thrive in their country in the second decade of the twenty-first century. But the violence that followed the jailing of this particular godman raises far more troubling questions than that.

The episode shows that India's much-vaunted economic growth and development has shallow roots indeed: that it has failed to deliver caste equality and social justice to the underclasses. It shows official institutions of governance all-too-readily subcontracting their responsibilities to religious orders, and enabling their leaders to live above the law. It shows the fragility of law and order systems, which failed so spectacularly in the face of mass fury. And it shows the hold of religious leaders on the loyalties, and the passions, of vast sections of people who find validation for their lives in such unthinking followership.

HINDU FATALISM